

A Christian reaction to the Supreme Court overturning of Row v Wade, and the approval of the COVID vaccine for infants.

A letter from Priest Seraphim. Sunday of the All Saints of Russia. 2nd Sunday after Pentecost.

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http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-06-26+all-saints-of-russia+roe-v-wade-vaccine.docx

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I'm trying very hard to send you something every week. I wrote some this past week when I was at a youth camp but didn't have a chance to finish it. The mornings started early at 4:30 AM on a good day and when I was really tired at 6:00 AM, and didn't end until about midnight. The camp was fantastic and I think our youth really benefited from it, but I got pretty tired! Therefore, my usual Friday (ish) letter is sent on the following Tuesday.

A Christian Reaction to the Supreme Court Overturning of Row v Wade.

Everyone knows by now that the landmark decision of Roe versus Wade has been reversed by the Supreme Court. We have a sermon between Vespers and Matins on Saturday night and I chose to speak about it. Normally a priest tries to avoid politics. However, we do live in the world, and politics is in it. I'm not interested in partisan politics, or even politics in general but I am interested in how a Christian should live in a political age. There is no doubt that the opinions of the public square directly influence the physical and moral and spiritual welfare of everyone. The homily on how a Christian should view the overturn of Roe versus Wade is forthcoming, but I did say words about it in response to someone online, and these words were the genesis for the homily. I will include a modified version of my original thoughts here.

The overturn of Roe versus Wade is certainly showing us how divided our country is, and even those who are in favor of the decision sometimes react in a way that I believe is not reasonable. As for those who oppose it and resort to bizarre rhetoric or even violence to "overturn" it, those folks would not listen to my words, so I'm not directing my words to them. They will only be helped by prayer (see below). I am directing my words to Christians.

There are those who want to celebrate this decision. I always thought when sports teams celebrated winning their division title, they were very premature. It was the championship that they should celebrate. I have no intention to celebrate this decision. There's still death and dying and people living in a way that will send them to hell. We are going to see the hounds of Hell released because abortion is one of the sacred cows of the religion of Moloch.

This is a step in the right direction. ***It is never right to do something wrong.*** Therefore, this is a good decision; however, there will be a lot of death and dying, and property destruction because of this decision. There will be lots of hatred expressed (it was already there) because of this decision. Babies will be saved, but souls are continuing to be lost. Millions of people still live in a way that is chaotic and immoral. Scores of women will be treated shamefully and left with little or no recourse when they get pregnant. Children will still live in poverty: economic poverty, and the poverty of the soul. Children will still be born to mothers and fathers that don't want to care for them or are unable to care for them. Babies will be born who do not know

their fathers. Society will still promote and covet the behaviors that will lead to more spiritual chaos in the soul, and pregnancies, and the desire of many to have an abortion. The mentally and spiritually ill whose identity is bound up with this demonic (former) law will be triggered and will act out in ways that are violent to others and toxic to their own souls. Those who are confused as to their personal identities and their gender identities and sexual ethics will continue to be bombarded with demonic lies which will make it even harder for them to find the truth about themselves. Therefore, I am not ready to celebrate.

Every day, I pray a short prayer for those who had abortions and those who have participated in them, and those who have forced others to get them. And I also pray short prayers related to the core issues that have caused us to come to a place in our life where evil is called good and killing is called a virtue. The enshrinement of abortion in national law for over 50 years is a symptom of the diseases of sexual promiscuity and perversity and an identity crisis that people have because they do not know God. Therefore, I also pray for all those who are confused as to their gender or their sexuality, or purpose in life.

These are not woke prayers. Woke people will not say these prayers because they celebrate the very things I am praying about. If you are celebrating, but you don't pray, then your celebration is hollow and worthless.

My advice to everyone who cares about life is to pray that we as a society live in a way that is truly alive! The only way to be truly alive is to live according to the truth. If we live according to the truth, then lies, which are darkness, will not be able to withstand the light of truth. This might sound impractical to many. I am not advocating that we do nothing but pray. I am advocating that what we do is nothing unless we also pray.

Should babies be given the COVID vaccine?

A shepherd, for the most part, comforts and teaches his flock. But there are times when he has to protect his sheep, and when there is danger, he cannot be subtle. Perhaps he must do things that frighten the sheep or do things the sheep do not like, in order to protect them. In the context of being a shepherd of men and women, and children, the shepherd must be unafraid to protect the sheep with forthright and open words. These words must be carefully measured, without diminishing their truthfulness. In the mountains, the sheep are in danger because of wolves, who seek to kill the sheep. In the world, the wolves are much more subtle, and deadly. They seek to kill the body or the soul, through coercion, habit, misinformation, promotion of the passions, and fear.

I am trying to measure my words carefully, but I cannot be silent. I have spoken forthrightly in private with many, but there are significant forces in our world that try to suppress public speech. This happens even in the church because being an Orthodox Christian does not automatically “immunize” a person against the toxic drone of society’s misplaced priorities and lies about what life is, and what it is not.

I want to warn you about the COVID vaccine. Two varieties of the vaccine have been approved for children as young as 6 months old. My warning will not be coercive or treat as the “other” those that do not have my opinion. I don’t want to ever be responsible for not being available to help someone who is confused or feels manipulated to get the vaccine, and has terrible side effects or even death because of it.

If you have any confusion about the vaccine, I would love to talk to you. I especially would love to talk to you if you are considering giving the vaccine to an infant or any child, especially a young girl.

We are in a time of life when our freedoms are being eroded: a frightening time, but we must pray we must have faith in God and we must not just listen to whatever “public service” announcement is being broadcast.

We will not ever in our church consider anyone to be the “other. That will never happen. Everyone is the same; we love everyone, and we accept the free will of everyone. Anyone can come to our church and worship. Nobody is going to be checked at the door to see if they have a vaccination or don't. We will not give the Holy Mysteries in any way other than they've always been given. There will be no services that are for the vaccinated only. That has happened in some Orthodox Churches! These churches have a distorted view of the Gospel. They have ceased to be churches of belief, but have become institutions of compliance to the narrative, coercion and fear, and the “othering” of people.

Therefore, if you're vaccinated, may God bless you, and may God grant you long life and eternal life!

If you're not vaccinated, may God bless you, and may God grant you long life and eternal life!

And if you have children that are vaccinated, then may God grant them wisdom and length of days and eternal life!

And if you have children that are not vaccinated, may God grant them wisdom and length of days and eternal life!

I will repeat, unlike some other Orthodox churches and even bishops: we will not segregate people based on their vaccination status or their opinion about the vaccine. But as a pastor, I must warn you that this vaccine has spiritual dimensions. I think the spiritual dimensions of the vaccine vary depending upon the spiritual disposition of a person who takes it. Some will have been forced to take the vaccine, and being minors they're not responsible for that action. I'm also aware of people who took the vaccine early in its distribution, not understanding exactly how things were going to play out. Some regret that now.

We do many things in our life that we regret, and God can help us with all of them.

If you regret taking the vaccine, then pray, follow the commandments, take communion more frequently, and there are regimens and protocols that will help you. We know of such things in our parish and we can direct a person to them.

If you do not regret taking the vaccine, then pray, follow the commandments, and take communion more frequently.

And if you have not taken the vaccine, then pray, follow the commandments, and take communion more frequently.

No matter what, if we do not pray and if we do not strive to live according to the only purpose in our life, we are lost regardless of whatever opinion we hold about the vaccine, and whether we are protected from COVID or not protected from it, and regardless if we contract COVID, or never become ill from it.

In Christ, unworthy Priest Seraphim.

This personal letter is an attempt to keep in touch. I don't know how to stay in touch in many circumstances because sometimes we haven't seen each other for a long time or we see each other irregularly, but I do know

how to write. It has become impossible for me to lay eyes on or greet everyone who comes to church on Sunday. If you reply to me, I'll do my best to write you soon as possible.

Recent stuff:

Confession talk at St Iakavos camp: what, why, how?

http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism_2022-06-23+confession-talk-at-st-iakavos-camp.mp3

Talk to youth at St Iakavos camp about confession, with Fr Seraphim and Sister Maxime. **WHAT** is it for, and what does the priest think of someone who confesses a terrible sin, and, **WHY** do we confess, **HOW** to prepare for it. And other stuff, such as what is the one thing in your life you cannot do without and why should we pray for anyone who harms us. IT is a lot, in about 25 minutes.

0:09 – 8:16 What is confession for?

8:25 – 11:29 Why pray for those who have harmed you, and how to pray for them.

11:29 – 13:42 What to confess? Not a list of "things"; it is not "formal". And about modern forms of confession that are not beneficial.

13:42 – 18:27 How do you prepare for confession? Concentrate on who you are, and your relationships.

18:35 – 22:03 What is one thing in your life you cannot do without?

22:05 – 25:15 What does the priest think about someone if they confess a terrible sin? Will his opinion of the person be negative

23:45 - 24:48 Sins of the flesh

The message of Pentecost: "I will give you an heart of flesh ...and ye shall be my people, and I will be your God."

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost_2022+a-heart-of-flesh+ye-shall-be-my-people-and-i-will-be-your-god.mp3

A quick exegesis of the three Vespers Old Testament readings for Pentecost, with much lingering on the last, from Ezekiel 36:24-28. Herein is the message (result) of Pentecost: "A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh. ...and ye shall be my people, and I will be your God."

8:41 the cure for a stony heart.

9:26 You must know that you can be a very bad person ... in order to become good. And 14:03 – 14:49

10:13 Ezekiel

Pentecost: The appointed day of promise, and the fulfillment of hope.

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost_2022+the-appointed-day-of-promise-and-the-fulfillment-of-hope.mp3

4:29 Commentary on the first hymn sung about Pentecost in the vigil: "We celebrate Pentecost, * and the descent of the Spirit, * and the appointed day of promise, and the fulfillment of hope. * And such a mystery! Both great and venerable! * Wherefore, we cry out unto Thee: * O Lord, Maker of all things, glory to Thee! " and a reflection on *what* the promise of Pentecost is, a promise unlike any other religion in the world. By Priest Nicholas Park

"In a little while ... your heart shall rejoice, and your joy no man taketh from you." Can we wait?

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-wed-07_2022+in-a-little-while_john16-15-23.mp3

2022-06-08 13 minutes. Exegesis of John 16:15-23, especially noting the apparent and spiritual meaning of: "a little while." Anything that is repeated in Scripture is important in this phrase is repeated five times. We also talk about the joy of the world which is as a psychotic laughing, and our joy, if we are can wait "a little while". We also talk about what we know of the next life. The Lord tells us that our sorrow will be turned into joy. He compares this joy to a woman who was given birth. If we understand even a little bit about this joy we will be able to wait "a little while."

Video: [New Martyr Alexander of Thessalonica +06-26-1794](#)

The New Martyr Alexander lived many years in deep apostasy before coming to his senses and being washed in the blood of martyrdom. His last hour alive on earth was very unique!

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/uo6PK0SDBdY>

[Christians live with the certainty that the future is in the present. High priestly prayer of Jesus Christ.](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sun-07_2022+holy-fathers+live-as-if-the-future-is-the-present_john17-1-13.mp3

Exegesis, with application to our lives, of the High Priestly prayer of Jesus Christ from John 17:1 through 13. We ask first why do we commemorate the fathers of the First Ecumenical Council and read this prayer on the Sunday before Pentecost? Then we go into all of the proofs that Jesus Christ is God and is completely equal to the Father, using the words of His prayer. And all of this must be applied! There are two applications. The first is that we must live in such a way that we are one with God since this is Jesus' prayer for us. We must understand what this means in order to live in this way. Our Lord also stated that He had completed the work that His Father had given him to do, even before He Jesus had been arrested and tried and crucified and all the rest. In chronological terms He had not completed the work but Christians live according to the future in the present. We talk about this at length. This is the only way to live especially in our troubled times when there will be many troubles coming. If we live only according to the present we will be lost if we live according to the future in our present, we will be saved. About 18min 2022-06-05

Partial (Audio) Timestamps.

0:17 – 1:28 Why commemorate the Fathers of the First Ecumenical council and read the high priestly prayer of Jesus Christ on the Sunday between Ascension and Pentecost?

1:28 – 7:27 All the parts of the High Priestly prayer of Jesus Christ which prove that He is God

3:53 – 4:17 “And this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent” John 17:3

4:17 – 5:49 “And now, O Father, glorify thou me with thine own self with the glory which I had with thee before the world was” (John 15:5)

5:49 – 6:28 “Now they have known that all things whatsoever thou hast given me are of thee. 8 For I have given unto them the words which thou gavest me; and they have received them, and have known surely that I came out from thee, and they have believed that thou didst send me” (John 17:7-8)

6:28 – 6:46 “And all mine are thine, and thine are mine; and I am glorified in them.” (John 17:10)

6:46 – 7:27 “Holy Father, keep through thine own name those whom thou hast given me, that they may be one, as we are” (John 17:11)

1:52 - 2:53 Why do we Orthodox stress so much the dogma that Jesus Christ is God and Man/ Why did 1000's of saints die to protect this dogma? What is the big deal?

5:01 – 5:41 We do not believe in “nice Jesus”, as much of the so-called Christian world believes.

7:27 – 10:06 The APPLICATION of the dogma that Jesus Christ is one with the Father, and His prayer: “Holy Father, keep through thine own name those whom thou hast given me, that they may be one, as we are.” And “these things I speak in the world, that they might have my joy fulfilled in themselves.”

10:06 – end APPLICATION of Jesus' prayer: “4 I have glorified thee on the earth: I have finished the work which thou gavest me to do” (John 17:4)

[Fathers of First Council. "Who hath rent thy garment?"](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sun-07_2022+fathers-of-first-council+who-hath-rent-thy-garment.mp3

Fr Nicholas gives an exegesis of one of the hymns from Vespers in honor of the Holy Fathers of the First Ecumenical Council: “O My Savior, who hath thus rent Thy raiment? / Thou didst say: It was Arius / who sundered the Trinity's headship, / which is one in rank and honor. / That Thou art One of the Most Holy Trinity he disputed: / and he taught Nestorius the godless not to say Theotokos. / But the Council gathered in Nicaea / proclaimed that Thou, O Lord, art truly the Son of God, // one with the Father and the Spirit in rank.” About 5 min. 2022-06-04

